

Inner subject prefixes to verbs (part 1)

The seven Witsuwit'en subjects represent the following meanings: 'I', 'you (sg.)', 'he/she/it', 'we (du.)', 'we', 'you (pl.)', 'they'. Six of these are marked by prefixes which are part of the verb. 'I', 'you (sg.)', 'we (du.)' and 'you (pl.)' are marked by *inner subject prefixes* on the verb. The inner prefixes always appear just before the final syllable of the verb. 'we' and 'they' are marked by *outer subject prefixes*.

Third person singular, 'he', 'she' or 'it', has no subject prefix. A verb lacking a subject prefix is simply interpreted as third person singular.

I' (First person singular, 1sg)

'I' is represented by one of three prefixes: **s-**, **c-** or **gi-**. The choice between **s-**, **c-** or **gi-** is entirely predictable from the sound or sounds that follow.

c- is used when the following sound is **lh-**. The third person singular subject form is given for comparison.

yecldic 'I'm talking'	yelhdic 'he's talking'
yiclh'is 'I'm sneezing'	yilh'is 'he's sneezing'
hiclhk'agh 'I'm fat'	hilhk'agh 'he's fat'

gi- is used when the following sounds are **l** plus another consonant:

tëgil'ën 'I'm pitiful' (poor me)'	tël'ën 'she's pitiful' (poor her)'
nigilc'ëkh 'I'm having a tantrum'	nilc'ëkh 'she's having a tantrum'
nigilgit 'I'm afraid'	nilgit 'she's afraid'
hagiltal 'I burst out laughing'	haltal 'she burst out laughing'

s- is used in all other cases (before all other sounds):

hisne 'I'm alive'	hine 'he's alive'
sisde 'I'm sitting'	sde 'he's sitting'
c'istl'o ~ c'istl'iw 'I'm knitting'	c'itl'o ~ c'itl'iw 'he's knitting'
nizsut 'I'm skating around'	nizut 'he's skating around'

With **s-** 1sg subject, there are only two small complications. (1) When the following sound is **l**, some speakers insert a **d** between the **s** and the **l**:

hisli ~ hisdli	'I am'
nisli ~ nisdli	'I'm carrying them (objects) around'
'islegh ~ 'isdlegh	'I made it'

When the following sound is **ts**, some speakers reduce **ts** to **s**:

histsagh ~ hissagh	'I'm crying'
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'We 2' (First person dual, 1du)

First person dual subject is marked by a prefix whose basic form is **dit-**. But there are some special cases.

First here are some examples of 'we (du.)' marked by **dit-**:

hiditcagh	'we (du.) are big'
hiditne	'we (du.) are alive'
sditkë	'we (du.) are sitting'
sditbiz	'we (du.) stretched it'
niditghï	'we (du.) are packing it around'

When the following sound is **'**, **dit'** is pronounced with **t'** as a unitary sound (rather than a syllable break in between t and **'**):

ïdit'ën 'we (du.) see him/her/it'	cf. is'ën 'I see it'
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When the following sound is **z** or **l**, **did-** rather than **dit-** occurs (with **dl** and **dz** pronounced as unitary sounds):

nididzut 'we (du.) are skating around'	cf. niszut 'I'm skating around'
udidzi 'we (du.) are calling his/her name'	uszi 'I'm calling his name'
hididli 'we (du.) are'	hisli ~ hisdli 'I am'
'ididlegh 'we (du.) made it'	'islegh ~ 'isdlegh 'I made it'

In the situation (before **l**) where the 1sg is **gi-**, the 1du is **di-**:

tëdil'ën 'we (du.) are pitiful' (poor us 2)	cf. tëgil'ën 'poor me'
nidilc'ëkh 'we (du.) are having a tantrum'	nigilc'ëkh 'I'm having a tantrum'

n**idil**git 'we (du.) are afraid'

nigilgit 'I'm afraid'

had**il**tal 'we (du.) burst out laughing'

hagiltal 'I burst out laughing'

However, instead of **sidil**-, the sequence **sdil**- occurs:

sdilc'ëgh 'we (du.) are mad (sitting and mad)'

cf. sigilc'ëgh 'I'm sitting mad'

ghis**dil**'ay 'we (du.) are each wearing it on ourselves (pin, badge, etc.)'

ghisigil'ay 'I'm wearing it'

Recall that 1sg subject is **c**- when the following sound is **lh**. In this same situation, 1du subject is **di**- and **lh** changes to **l**:

ye**dil**dic 'we (du.) are talking'

cf. yeclhdic 'I'm talking'

y**idil**'is 'we (du.) are sneezing'

yiclh'is 'I'm sneezing'

ï**dil**cot 'we (du.) took it, are taking it'

ïclhcot 'I'm taking it, took it'

n**idil**'ën 'we (du.) are looking at him/her/it'

nielh'ën 'I'm looking at it'

'**idil**'ah 'we (du.) are working on it'

'iclh'ah 'I'm working on it'

hi**dilk**'agh 'we (du.) are fat'

hielhk'agh 'I'm fat'

Here too we find **sdil** rather than **sidil**:

sdilc'ilh 'we (du.) bit him/her/it'

siclhc'ilh 'I bit it'

sdilghil 'we (du.) bundled it'

siclhghil 'I bundled it'

The final special case for the 1du subject prefix is that when the following consonant is one of **d t t' dz ts ts' dl tl tl'**, **di**- occurs (rather than **did**- or **dit**-):

hi**di**tsagh

'we (du.) are crying'

c'**iditl**'o ~ c'**iditl**'iw

'we (du.) are knitting'

Writing practice

The following words will be dictated to you. Pay particular attention to the subject prefix as you write these words.

_____	'let me eat it'
_____	'let us (du.) eat it'
_____	'I keep it in the car'
_____	'we (du.) keep it in the car'
_____	'I became'
_____	'we (du.) became'
_____	'I look like him/her'
_____	'we (du.) look like him/her'
_____	'let me jump into it (bus, car, etc.)'
_____	'let us (du.) jump into it'

Imperfective and progressive

The expression of time categories in the verb is fairly complex in Witsuwit'en. Here we will focus on the marking of the verb in the present. The technical name for this category in Dene linguistics is *imperfective*. A special case of the imperfective is the *progressive*.

Imperfective

The imperfective actually marks a category which is an ongoing, incomplete activity or state. This is usually translated into English using the present tense. The basic form of the imperfective is the prefix **i-**, occurring to the left of the inner subject prefixes:

n**i**gilgit

'I'm afraid'

n**i**dilgit

'we (du.) are afraid'

However, this vowel is often not present because it is regularly absent in certain contexts, one of these being after a vowel, so even though the following are imperfective verbs, the imperfective vowel **i** is not in these forms after the vowel **e** of the prefix **ye**, part of the verb 'talk'.

yeclhdic

'I'm talking'

yedildic

'we (du.) are talking'

Progressive

A special case of the imperfective is called the progressive, and is marked by a prefix **ë** or **ï** to the left of the inner subject prefixes. Not all verbs have a progressive form in Witsuwit'en, but one of the most common types of verbs, motion verbs, has a progressive. The meaning is simply that the activity is taking place, here and now:

ïgilggïh

'I'm running'

ïdilggïh

'we (du.) are running'

d**ï**gildis

'I'm going fast'

d**ï**dildis

'we (du.) are going fast'

(The vowel **ë** of the progressive must be used when the preceding consonant is one of:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	,
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

We will see examples later on.)

Writing practice: 1sg. and 1du. subjects and progressive or imperfective

Given the following third person singular subject verbs, create first person singular or dual subject versions. Change any other elements in the sentence (such as postpositional prefixes) as needed to create a grammatical sentence.

Example:

ikēlh

‘he’s boating’

‘I’m boating’

‘we (du). are boating’

Answers:

iskēlh

īditkēlh

‘I’m boating’

‘we (du). are boating’

nīl’ēlh

‘he’s sneaking’

‘I’m sneaking’

‘we (du.) are sneaking’

īgguh

‘he’s driving’

‘I’m driving’

‘we (du.) are driving’

nikwiz

‘he’s driving around’

‘I’m driving around’

‘we (du.) are driving around’

nit'agh

'he's flying around'

'I'm flying around'

'we're flying around'

ilc'oh

'he's walking and he's mad'

'I'm walking and I'm mad'

'we (du.) are walking and we're mad'

ibilh

'he's swimming'

'I'm swimming'

'we (du.) are swimming'

këdizilh

'he's travelling'

'I'm travelling'

'we (du.) are travelling'

yilh iltsilh

'he's chasing him'

'I'm chasing him'

'we (du.) are chasing him'